

HUM14-3

Philosophy I — The Examined Life

Authentic desire, freedom and responsibility, ethics under pressure

Thinkers as diagnostic instruments, not authorities.

Albert School — 12 hours

Preface

This module treats philosophy as a clarification tool. Each chapter opens from a real tension and introduces thinkers as diagnostic instruments to wield, not positions to memorise. The guiding question throughout is “what does this framework help us see that the others miss?” rather than “what did this thinker believe?” Agreement with any canonical position is irrelevant to evaluation: the sole criterion is the rigour of the argument — its premises, its inferences, and whether the conclusion follows.

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1 Evaluating philosophical arguments

An argument consists of premises and a conclusion. Evaluating its rigour means checking three things, independently of whether one agrees with the conclusion:

- **Premises:** are the stated starting points true, or at least defensible?
- **Inferences:** does each step follow from what precedes it?
- **Validity of the whole:** does the conclusion actually follow from the premises, or has something been smuggled in?

A conclusion one likes can rest on a bad argument; a conclusion one rejects can rest on a good one. Throughout the module this criterion is applied to one’s own positions and to peers’ positions under adversarial pressure: a claim survives only if it withstands objection.

2 Three frameworks for authentic desire

The tension: what one believes one wants versus what one actually wants. Three frameworks evaluate the authenticity of a desire, each seeing something the others miss.

2.1 Aristotelian eudaimonia

For Aristotle the highest human good is *eudaimonia* — flourishing, a complete life lived well according to reason and virtue. A desire is authentic to the extent that satisfying it contributes to this flourishing rather than to passing pleasure. Eudaimonia is an activity of the soul over a

whole life, not a momentary state, and it serves here as a criterion: does this desire move me toward a life that is good as a whole?

2.2 Girardian mimetic desire

For Girard, desire is *mimetic*: we do not desire objects directly and spontaneously, but copy the desires of others, who serve as models. What looks like one's own want is often borrowed from a model whose wanting we imitate. The diagnostic value of this framework is suspicion: a desire that feels most one's own may be the most imitated, and rivalry with the model is its frequent result.

2.3 Spinoza's conatus

For Spinoza each thing strives to persevere in its being; this striving is the *conatus*. Joy is the felt increase of one's power to act, sadness its decrease. A desire is to be evaluated by whether acting on it increases one's genuine power to act — and therefore one's joy — or diminishes it. This gives an internal criterion that does not depend on an external standard of the good.

2.4 Using the three together

The three frameworks compete. Aristotle asks whether the desire fits a whole life lived well; Girard asks whether the desire is even one's own or borrowed from a model; Spinoza asks whether acting on it increases one's power to act. Each exposes a blind spot of the others — for instance, Girard's question of whether a desire is imitated is invisible to Aristotle's question of whether it fits a good life.

3 Freedom and responsibility

The tension: freedom versus constraint. Two frameworks divide the territory differently.

3.1 Epictetus's dichotomy of control

For the Stoic Epictetus, the first task is to distinguish what is **up to us** from what is **not up to us**. Up to us are our judgements, choices, and responses; not up to us are external events, the body, reputation, and the actions of others. Freedom and tranquillity come from directing effort only at what is within our control and accepting the rest. Misery comes from staking oneself on what is not up to us.

3.2 Sartre's radical responsibility and bad faith

For Sartre, the human being is radically free and therefore radically responsible: we are “condemned to be free”, and we cannot escape choosing, since even refusing to choose is a choice. *Bad faith* is the self-deception by which a person denies this freedom — pretending that circumstances, a role, or one's nature left no choice. Bad faith is thus an escape from the responsibility that freedom imposes.

3.3 Applying the two frameworks

Applied to a real personal or professional dilemma, the two frameworks pull apart. Epictetus directs attention to the boundary between what is and is not within one's control, counselling acceptance beyond it. Sartre denies any such alibi: within the situation one is always choosing, and attributing the choice to circumstance is bad faith. The exercise is to apply both to the same dilemma and distinguish what is genuinely within one's control from what is not.

4 Three ethical frameworks under pressure

The tension: efficiency versus ethics, and cases where doing right by one standard violates another. Three frameworks are applied to **the same** ethical case, each made to state explicitly what it sacrifices.

4.1 Kantian deontology

Kant's *categorical imperative* commands acting only on a maxim one could will to become a universal law, and treating humanity — in oneself and others — always as an end and never merely as a means. Rightness lies in the principle of the action, not its consequences. **What it sacrifices:** it can demand an action whose consequences are bad, because outcomes do not enter the judgement.

4.2 Millian utilitarianism

Mill's utilitarianism judges an action right in proportion as it tends to produce the greatest happiness for the greatest number, counting each person's happiness equally. **What it sacrifices:** it can justify harming an individual when doing so maximises aggregate happiness, because the individual has no standing the total cannot override.

4.3 Aristotelian virtue ethics

Virtue ethics asks not “what rule applies?” or “what maximises good?” but “what would a person of good character do here?” The right action is the one a virtuous person, exercising practical wisdom, would choose — typically a mean between excess and deficiency. **What it sacrifices:** it gives no mechanical decision procedure, and offers little guidance when it is precisely unclear what the virtuous person would do.

4.4 The point of the comparison

Applied to one case, the three frameworks can recommend different actions and, even when they agree, justify the action differently. The required move is to apply all three to the same case and acknowledge explicitly what each one sacrifices, rather than adopting one and ignoring its cost.

5 Success versus the good life

Inherited definitions of success — wealth, status, recognition — are examined against the criteria built above. Two operational criteria are used in place of inherited success:

- **Eudaimonia:** does this contribute to a whole life lived well, or only to a momentary or external marker?
- **Power to act** (Spinoza's *conatus*): does this increase the person's genuine power to act, or merely their exposure to external judgement?

A real-world professional scenario — a career choice, an ambition, a life design — is evaluated by asking whether it increases genuine power to act or merely increases exposure to the judgement of others. Success on inherited terms and a good life can diverge: the question makes the divergence visible.

6 Constructing and defending a thesis

The module culminates in a defended personal thesis on what living well means. A rigorous thesis has the following structure:

- **A clear claim** about the good life, stated so it can be argued for and against.

- **Two thinkers in productive tension:** two of the frameworks above mobilised together so that their disagreement does work, rather than one cited as an authority.
- **A serious counter-argument:** the strongest objection taken seriously, stated in its most forceful form rather than a weak version chosen to be easy to defeat.
- **An answer to the objection,** and a **defence under peer objection** delivered live.

The thesis is judged solely on the rigour of its argument — premises, inferences, and whether the conclusion follows — and not on whether the reader agrees with its conclusion or with any canonical position it invokes.